

Session 7: Abram and Lot Separate

Key Takeaways

- Avram's ill-gotten wealth becomes the source of conflict, causing him to part ways with Lot.
- Lot is enticed by a false Eden and chooses what is good in his own eyes.
- The separation of Avram and Lot is set on analogy to the failure narratives of Genesis 3, 4, and 6.
- The separation of the brothers motif is the Bible's way of exploring communal sin.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 13:1-4

a ¹ And Avram went up out of Egypt,
b he and his wife
b and **all that belonged to him** ,
b and **Lot** with him,
a' **to the Negev.**

a ² And Avram was very heavy
b with **herds**
b and with **silver**
b and with **gold** ,

a ³ and he went on **his journeys from the Negev** and unto **Beth-El (= house of El)**
b **unto the place** where **his tent** was there **at the first** ,
c **between Beth-El** and between Ai,
b' ⁴ **to the place** of **the altar** which he built **there** **at the beginning** ,
a' and Avram called **there** on **the name of Yahweh** .

Genesis 13:1-4. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Avram's Exodus From Egypt ... With Lot

The scene opens with Avram's ascent (literally "he went up" עָלָה) from Egypt with much wealth. Multiple links back to [12:5-9](#) show us that Yahweh's deliverance has restored him to his former estate.

Avram's Entry Into the Land

Genesis 12:5, 8-9 Instructor's Translation

⁵ And **Avram** took Sarai **his wife**,
and **Lot** the son of his brother,
and **all the possessions** they came to possess ...
and they went to the land of Canaan.

⁸ And he moved on (ויעתק) from there
to the hill from the east of Beth-El
and **he spread out his tent**
Beth-El on the west
and Ai from the East
and he built there an altar to Yahweh
and he called upon the name of Yahweh.

⁹ And Avram journeyed (ויסע),
continually **journeying** (נסוע) **to the Negev.**

Avram's Reentry Into the Land

Genesis 13:1, 3-4 Instructor's Translation

¹ And **Avram** went up out of Egypt,
he and **his wife**,
and **all that belonged to him**,
and **Lot** with him,
to the Negev.

³ And he went on **his journeys from the Negev**,
even **unto Beth-El**,
unto the place **where his tent was** there at the first,
between Beth-El and between Ai,

⁴ to the place of **the altar which he built** there at the beginning,
and **Avram called there on the name of Yahweh.**

Lot's presence with Avram's company was mentioned back in 12:5, and he remained in the background for all of 12:6-9 and 12:10-20. Lot's problematic presence is reintroduced here because he will play the key role in the narrative to follow.

There is another key difference between Avram's descent and ascent from Egypt. Avram is extremely wealthy now, and that wealth, gained from his deception of Pharaoh, is also going to play a major role in the next narrative.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 13:5-11

⁵ Now, also **belonging to Lot**,
who went with **Avram**,

^u were **flocks and cattle and tents** ,
 b ⁶ and **the land** could not carry them for **dwelling together as one** (יחדו) ,
 a' because **their possessions** were **so many** (רב) ,
 b' and **they were not able to** **dwelling together as one** (יחדו) .
 a ⁷ And there was a **dispute** (ריב)
 b **between** **the shepherds of the herd of** **Avram**
 b' and **between** **the shepherds of the herd of** **Lot**
 c (now, the Canaanites and the Perizzites were then **dwelling** in **the land**).

⁸ And **Avram** said to **Lot** ,
 a "Don't let there be **disputing** (מריבה)
 b **between** **me and** **between** **you** ,
 b' **between** **my shepherds and** **between** **your shepherds** ,
 a' for **we men are brothers!** (אח)
⁹ Isn't **all the land** before you?
 Please, **separate from me** !
 If you go left/north, I will go right/south,
 and if you go right/south, I will go left/north."

a ¹⁰ And Lot **lifted his eyes** ,
and he saw all the **valley of the** **Jordan** ,
that it was entirely **watered**
 b **(this is before Yahweh caused the ruin of Sodom and Gomorrah)**
it was like **the** **garden** of Yahweh,
 a' **like the land of** **Egypt**
as you go to **Zoar** .
 a ¹¹ And Lot chose for himself all **the** **valley of the** **Jordan** ,
 a' and Lot journeyed **eastward** ,
 b and **each man separated from his brother** .

Genesis 13:5-11. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The Division of the Brothers

The developing conflict between Avram and Lot happens in steps that are carefully marked in the text's progression.

We're told that Lot also has many herds, alongside Avram's many herds. This leads to a problem of capacity. The land simply can't sustain all of their grazing cattle. "It cannot carry them for dwelling together as one."

Notice the additional reason for the land's inability to sustain Avram and Lot's herds: They are not the only ones grazing their cattle in this land. The Canaanites also dwell in the land. The symmetrical design of the paragraph delays the information about the Canaanites while also linking it back up to the inability of Lot and Avram to live together.

However, the land's inability isn't the only reason for the conflict. There is also the matter of their "possessions." There is an important wordplay with the description of the "many" (רב, *rav*) possessions, which leads to a "dispute" (ריב, *riv*) between the brothers. Specifically, the dispute is between the shepherds of each party, i.e., between those who are not brothers.

Avram's Solution and the Promised Land at Risk

Genesis 13:8-9 Instructor's Translation

⁸ And Avram said to Lot,
"Don't let there be disputing
between me and between you,
between my shepherds and between your shepherds,
for we men are brothers!
⁹ Isn't all the land before you?
Please, separate from me!
If you go left/north, I will go right/south,
and if you go right/south, I will go left/north."

Avram's speech is an attempt to avoid escalating conflict, and a subtle wordplay with the preceding paragraph shows the narrative's emphasis.

Genesis 13:6 Instructor's Translation

and the land could not carry them for **dwelling together as one** (יחדו), because their possessions were so many (רב), and they weren't able to **dwelt together as one** (יחדו)

"dwell together as one" = Heb. *yakhdav*

Genesis 13:11 Instructor's Translation

and **each man separated from his brother** (אחיו)

"his brother" = Heb. *'akhiv*

Genesis 13:8 Instructor's Translation

"Don't let there be disputing (מריבה) between me and between you, between my shepherds and your shepherds, for we men are **brothers!**" (אחים)

"brothers" = Heb. *'akhim*

Avram names the sad reality that even though they are brothers, they are not able to dwell together as one because their many possessions have created jealousy, contention, and division. And so his solution is both generous and risky. He lets Lot have his choice of grazing lands first.

Lot Saw That It Was Good ... and He Took

The depiction of Lot choosing his ideal grazing land is full of hyperlinks back to Genesis 1-11, and these links help the reader evaluate his actions.

Genesis 13:10-11 Instructor's Translation

¹⁰ And Lot lifted his eyes,
and he saw all the valley of the Jordan,
that it was entirely watered
(this is before Yahweh caused the ruin of Sodom and Gomorrah)
it was like the garden of Yahweh,
like the land of Egypt
as you go to Zoar.
¹¹ And Lot chose for himself all the valley of the Jordan,
and Lot journeyed eastward,
and each man separated from his brother.

Genesis 3:6 Instructor's Translation

And the woman saw the tree, **that it was good** for eating, that it was desirable to the eyes, and **she took** from its fruit and she ate ...

Genesis 3:24 Instructor's Translation

And [Yahweh] banished the human, and stationed *kheruvim* at the **east of the garden of Eden** ...

Genesis 6:2 Instructor's Translation

And **the sons of elohim saw** the daughter of humanity, **that they were good**, and **they took** for themselves wives, from all that they chose.

Lot and Eve

Lot's decision is set on analogy to Eve's foolish choice to do what was good in her eyes. Just as her evaluation of what was good was faulty and led to death, Lot's choice of what appeared to be Eden also turns out to be misguided. In Eve's case, this led to exile to the east of Eden, and in Lot's case, it leads to a self-imposed "exile" from the Eden-like promised land.

Lot and the Sons of *Elohim*

The sons of *elohim* invert the folly of Eve as they see, take, and choose for themselves what is good in their eyes. Lot does the same thing, but not in relation to women. Rather, what he sees, takes, and chooses is an Eden-like land. And ironically, the place he chooses is the very city where Genesis 6:2 will be inverted! In Sodom, human men will try to have sex with angels, and Lot himself will take his good-looking daughters and try to give them to these men! It's a tragic portrait of how selfish choices have a cascading effect that builds in intensity and scope.

Brothers and Waters Separate Outside of Eden

The use of the word “separate” (Heb. *parad*, פָּרַד) to describe the sibling rivalry and division between Avram and Lot sets up analogies to the earlier story of division between Cain and Abel, and between the sons of Noah, and, surprisingly, between the river of Eden.

Genesis 13:10-11 Instructor’s Translation

¹⁰ And Lot lifted his eyes,
and he saw all the valley of the Jordan,
that it was entirely watered
(this is before Yahweh caused the ruin of Sodom and Gomorrah)
it was like the garden of Yahweh,
like the land of Egypt
as you go to Zoar.
¹¹ And Lot chose for himself all the valley of the Jordan,
and Lot journeyed eastward,
and each man separated from his brother.

Genesis 2:10, 14 Instructor’s Translation

10 Now, a **river went out from Eden** to **water the garden**; and from there **it separated** and became four heads ... ¹⁴ and the name of the third river is Tigris; it goes **east** of Assyria.

Genesis 4:16-17 Instructor’s Translation

¹⁶ and Cain **went out from the face of Yahweh**, and he dwelt in the land of Wandering/Nod, **east of Eden**. ¹⁷
And Cain ... built a city, and called the name of the city “Enoch,” according to the name of his son.

Genesis 9:18 Instructor’s Translation

And the sons of Noah who **went out of the ark**, were Shem and Ham and Japheth.

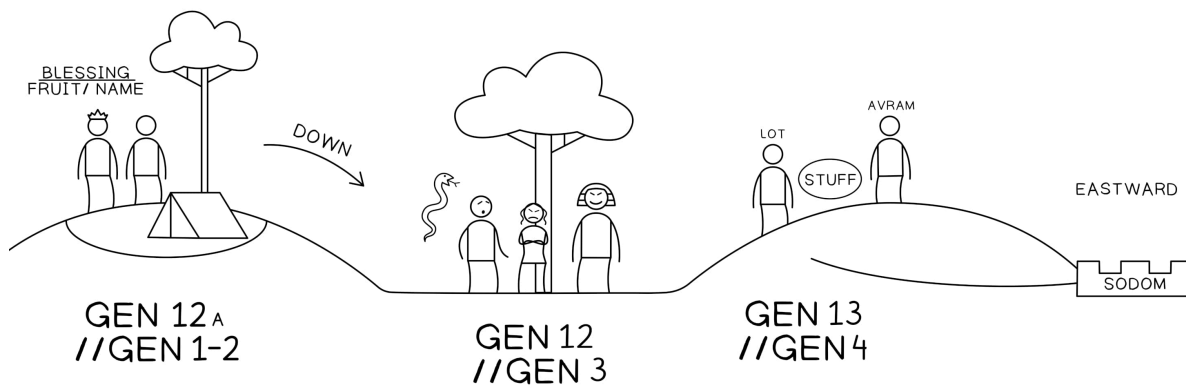
Genesis 10:11-12 Instructor’s Translation

From [Babylon Nimrod] went forth into Assyria and he built Nineveh ... the great city.

Genesis 10:32 Instructor’s Translation

These are the families of the sons of Noah ... and out of these **the nations were separated** on the land after the flood.

Brothers Separate



Avram and Lot Separating. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Reflection Question

How does the narrative tell us that Lot makes a foolish decision?